hills to the south of the town and as the day advanced they came swarming up the rocky heights'.[80]

The city gates were closed, but just before that Sale sent a last express messenger out in the hope that he could get safely down the Khyber and reach the British Residency at Peshawar. 'Be pleased to acquaint the Com in Chief', he scribbled on a scrap of paper,

> that we are surrounded on every side by the insurgents. Two regts and a corps of sappers do not more than suffice to man these extensive walls and great efforts are demanded of us. We want treasure immediately as well as 20,000 rounds of musquet ammunition. In fact we need succour in every way, troops, treasure, provision and ammunition, and now. Measures must be prompt to be useful to us. The troops are placed on half rations, and we have only six days rice and no atta.[81]

The siege of Jalalabad had begun.

Across southern Afghanistan, a mass uprising was now clearly imminent.

In Kandahar, Rawlinson believed that 'the feeling against us is daily on the increase and I apprehend a succession of disturbances . . . Their mullahs are preaching against us from one end of the country to the other.'[82] His military counterpart, General Nott, was in agreement, writing to his daughters in despair that 'this country is in a sad state . . . Sir Wm Macnaghten's mistakes and weak system begin to tell most woefully; it must be changed or we must walk out of this part of the world . . . It may take many years to undo what that man, Macnaghten, has done. How could Lord Auckland allow such a man to remain in authority here, bringing into contempt everything connected with the name of Englishmen?'[83]

In Ghazni, the commander of the garrison there, Colonel Thomas Palmer, was equally anxious, writing to Nott that 'the country here is getting more disturbed every day . . . I see not how General Sale's Brigade is to leave the country. Of course they might force their way through, but the enemy would close on their rear, and cut off our communications with India as completely as it has been done for the past fortnight.'[84] Most alarmed of all was Eldred Pottinger in Charikar, who was now so certain that his small garrison of Gurkhas was about to be massacred that he rode back to Kabul to reason with Elphinstone and Macnaghten in person. Elphinstone sat looking panicked, then dithered and fussed, but failed to send him any concrete